

It shouldn't be like this.

Even Lilith knows that.

She was born imperfect, she was told. Born without cause, against fate, against the *natural laws*.

She and her sister both.

She was twelve when she had learnt that her hands were her own, that they weren't shackled by the constraints of the rules; that her legs followed her own will, not the will of her mother and father, who only ever saw her as an extra piece in the set, a worthless addition to the family.

The mantles of worth and the family legacy had fallen upon her sister, Misha, who was older than her by a mere seven minutes. Both girls had been unexpected, and, had either of them had been boys, they would have been better off.

In a way, she was jealous. Jealous of Misha. Jealous of the attention she got, jealous of the life that Misha got to live. It seemed simpler, kinder. Misha never got hurt. Misha never got shoved around. Misha never spoke of her life being a difficult mess.

All Lilith had in her life was pain. She hated her own existence, and had learnt to apologise for it, as if that were compensation for what she never could be: a favoured son, or a son at all.

Tonight, she takes to trying to get away from home, to running away and never coming back. The pull to the vast land that stretched beyond her window screamed and fought against the rest of her instincts, a pull that was far too strong to ignore now. It's been like that for the last few days, her eyes instinctively looking through the nearest window, longing for a place she's never been.

She tries her window, the one her parents repeatedly told her to never open. *The worst thing that can happen*, Lilith thinks to herself as she slowly pushes it outwards, *is that I get caught outside and they bring me back in.*

She repeats the thought like a mantra, like gospel she isn't quite sure she's allowed to keep. She sits on her windowsill, looking down at the three storeys of brick she needs to climb down. The climb down seems exhausting, and she knows that it won't be a simple straight climb down. If she gets caught...

The worst thing that can happen is that I get caught outside and they bring me back in.

Lilith takes a deep breath, looking down again at the plush grass at the bottom. The drop seems to be getting deeper by the second. It shouldn't work like that, her eyes are most likely playing tricks. But it seems so real. She runs her hand through her short, blonde hair, effectively pushing it out of her face, before she decides to trust herself, to slip herself off the windowsill and fit her toe against one of the cracks between the bricks.

No, nope, no. Absolutely not.

She pulls herself back up, closing her window, and crawling back into bed. She will never attempt that again.

The next night she tries again. She sits on the edge of her window sill, her legs dangling out, looking down at the drop. She doesn't let herself look down for too long, slipping off the window sill and climbing down. The fresh air was odd, she realises. And climbing down is a lot more exhausting than she thought it would be.

By the time her feet touch the ground, sweat is dripping down her forehead, the back of her shirt is soaked. It wasn't hard to climb down.

That was definitely her pride speaking.

She walks for a long while, and with every step she revels in the fact that this means freedom. She's found a way out of her bedroom, she's found a way out from her parents.

But Misha will be alone then...

The thought tugs at her, a pit forms in her stomach.

Okay, she can go back afterwards. Maybe this tiny walk at night would help her stay sane, and she can just return before her parents know she's gone.

Eventually, she comes across a vast lake. She's never seen one with her own eyes. The water glimmers in the moonlight, reflecting in the most beautiful patterns. There are few trees, enough to provide some shade in the daytime, should she ever visit then. She doubts she would be able to.

The moonlight is good enough. In fact, it's the most beautiful sight she's ever seen. She doesn't ever want to look away, completely entranced by how the water ebbs and flows against the rocks and pebbles beneath her feet. She slowly kneels down near the water, extending her hand to touch it.

The cold shocks her. She gasps as she pulls her hand back, losing her balance and falling back.

"Hm. That's a sight."

She whips around, trying to find the source of the voice. It wasn't her father's thick, stern voice, nor was it her mother's honey-lined one. It simply was... a voice. Of a boy. Not a man. A boy. She knew that much.

She's never spoken with a boy for more than a few sentences. It wasn't her parents' fault. She simply was too scared to speak to the boy. But now there's a boy somewhere here.

Nowhere she can see, though. She scrambles to her feet, wiping her wet fingertips onto her brown pants, the ones she had specifically kept for the day she went outside without her parents. She goes towards the tree where she had heard the voice from. Checks behind it.

No one's there.

Maybe she had just imagined the voice. She can't be going crazy yet. It's barely been that long since she left home.

"Over here, silly."

She whips around. She pushes her short hair out of her face. *This boy is nowhere.*

She swallows hard. She scans the area around her with eyes wide as a frightened doe. "Hello," she says in a quiet, shaky voice, taking slow steps towards the tree in front of her. Her fingers wring themselves, She gets no response. Well, clearly, this boy is playing tricks on her.

He jumped out from behind the tree. "Boo!"

She screamed, stumbling back. She fell back onto the grass. He simply stood there, arms crossed over his chest, looking down at her with a smirk and raised eyebrows.

She quickly gets to her feet once again, brushing herself off. "You scared me! That's rude." She folds her arms over her chest, mirroring his pose, looking right into his eyes.

"'Rude' is subjective, and I don't think I was rude," he counters, the grin wide on his face. He looks like one of those princes she reads about in the few stories she's allowed to read: short blond hair, wide flashy smile. She can't quite see the colour of his eyes. But she isn't a princess, and life isn't a storybook, so it doesn't matter if he looks like a storybook prince or not. "My name is Aries."

"I'm—" she starts, pausing for a short second. She's never introduced herself before. "Lilith."

“That’s a terrible name,” he says, sitting down on the grass. “You should think of a better one.”

Lilith opens her mouth to speak. Shuts it. Scoffs. “You have a terrible name!”

“No I don’t,” he says, looking up at her, leaning back on his hands. “I have the most perfectest name to ever exist.”

“You speak badly.”

“Or I speak freely,” he counters. “We’ll never know. Sit down.” He pats the ground beside him.

Lilith drops down, crossing her legs with her hands in her lap, her back straight. “I don’t want a new name.”

“To each their own, I guess. I think you should get a new name.” He lies down on the grass, his arms folded beneath his head.

Lilith stared at him, narrowing her eyes. “I have a feeling you’re always this annoying—”

“Correct!”

“—And that you’re really stupid.”

He gasps, sitting up. “Now *that* is rude, *Lil-lith*. You can’t call people stupid, it’s mean.”

“Maybe you should’ve thought about that before insulting my name.” She looks out at the lake again.

“It hurt my feelings.”

“Sorry,” she mumbles. “But you hurt my feelings too.”

“Sorry,” he replies just as quietly. He follows her gaze out to the water. “I don’t have many friends. You’re the first person I’ve seen here.”

“Oh,” Lilith said, looking down at the grass beneath her. It was quite spiky. She hadn’t expected that. Grass always seemed plush and comfortable. Maybe it was just because this grass was wild grass and not the grass they had at home. “I haven’t any friends either.”

“Then we can be friends! Maybe coming here every day for the last while hasn’t been for nothing.” He relaxes down into the grass again, his arms folded beneath his head. “Come on, don’t be shy, Lilith. I should give you a nickname, actually.”

“I don’t—”

“Don’t be silly, of course you need one! Everyone gets a nickname when they make friends.”

“Oh,” is all Lilith can say in reply. She pulls at the grass, feeling that pull in her stomach again, like a monster is trying to claw its way out, tear her soul to pieces and emerge as someone different using her name and skin to trick people. The thought made her want to vomit. Instead, her stomach churned and pulled like it had been for months.

Lilith tries to swallow down the feeling again, like she had been doing, especially around her parents, who hate weakness above all else. That’s when Aries spoke.

“You don’t have to hide it, you know. You look about as green as the grass,” he points out. “People aren’t supposed to look that green.”

“I don’t look *green*, Aries,” Lilith says with a pout. “I’m just... not feeling well, that’s all. I’m fine.”

“I just said you don’t have to pretend.”

“I’m not pretending.”

“And don’t lie, either. That’s mean.”

“I’m not lying.”

With that, Lilith stands, and slowly makes her way back to the water. When she turns to see if Aries is following, he’s nowhere to be seen. Lilith turns a full circle, looking for where he possibly can be, before spotting him already with a hand in the water.

“You teleported,” she says, joining him by his side and squatting down to tread her fingers through the crystal waves again. Each wave stings like a frozen lash, lapping against her pale skin, but, surprisingly, this time she *likes* the feeling. She turns her hands, encapsulated by the sight of her fingers warping with the glittering water.

“I like to think I know how to teleport,” Aries says with his white-toothed smile.
“Maybe that’s my affinity.”

“I haven’t gotten my affinity yet,” Lilith mumbles. “It seems like everyone has gotten it before me.”

“Your affinity is closer than you think,” Aries replies. Lilith looks up at him. His eyes are still settled on the water. “At least, that’s what my parents tell me all the time. So maybe it applies to you, too.”

Maybe her affinity is closer than she thought. The thought makes her hope— this boy makes her hope.

Hope is a very dangerous thing. She cannot show hope of her affinity if it doesn’t come. She would disappoint her parents. If they start believing in her, *loving her*, even, and she doesn’t fulfill the expectations placed upon her, they would not be pleased.

They would stop caring about her. They would throw her out. They would *hate her*.

“I think... I think I should go,” Lilith says slowly as she stands and stumbles away from the water. Her voice shook as the fear of hope set in.

Aries gave her a weird look, her sudden retreat startling him. But then his expression smooths out into a neutral one, his eyes becoming blank. Lilith turns away from him, stepping back onto the grass to begin the journey home again.

“You’ll be back,” Aries says quietly.

When Lilith turns back to see him one last time, he was already gone, and the tugging in her stomach vanished alongside him.

Lilith hummed a song she learnt in her tutoring under her breath as she went home.

In the days following, she slowly forgot the boy’s face. Her mind could only form pictures of him hazy, glowing dimly (though she knew people couldn’t glow, and that idea was silly altogether), a wide smile and loud laugh—but not the loud laugh that startled, it was a kinder laugh, an inviting one.

Lilith lays her head down on the grass by Aries' leg. His hand finds her hair, pushing it away from her face. "Tell me a story," she says quietly. "Not... not a storybook story. Something real."

Aries exhales deeply. For a long while, he says nothing as he threads his fingers through her thin hair and they both stare out at the lake they've met by for the past year. "I don't know many... *real* stories, but I can try my best," he says eventually.

Another lull of silence follows, and Lilith begins to wonder if he'll speak before her eyelids get too heavy to keep open.

"Once upon a time there were two children," he says quietly, his eyes locked onto the lake. "One was a girl who sought refuge from the horrors of home. The other was a boy who sought company in the dying light of day. They met by chance one night. They quarreled."

Lilith laughs softly. "This is about us."

His hand stilled in her hair. “Shut up. You asked for something real.”

“Fine.”

He cleared his throat, deepening his voice back into storyteller mode. “There were no reasons for them to trust one another. He was loud, yes, but also charming, handsome, an excellent talker, and had a great laugh—he still does. She was grumpy and short and—”

“Aries.”

“Fine, fine. She was also pretty nice and wore a pretty dress and stuff. They got to know one another, despite all odds. They met over and over by the same lake. Sometimes he would arrive and she wouldn’t come. But he was always there, night after night, hour after hour, waiting for her to come. Sometimes days passed. But she would always return.

“Like clockwork the two met at the same time each night. She would fight her way out of prison to meet him. He would fight his way out of hell to meet her. Until one day, she arrived in tears.”

“I’ve never come here in tears.”

“I never said this was about you,” he counters. He begins to comb her hair back with his fingers again. “She arrived in tears. He offered her a solution. He began to tell her about a new world. One far away from the suffering and pain and heartbreak.

“He knew a world where that was all possible, where they could be free. It was a simple solution. All she had to do was listen to her friend, and he’ll take her there. All she had to do was go with him.”

He gently guides Lilith to sit up, looking her in the eyes as he takes her hand in his. His finger circles her palm. “Tell me if she wants to follow him,” he whispers quietly. When she nods, he produces a pair of scissors, pressing them into her palm and closing her fingers. He

doesn't lift his eyes from her hand as he speaks. "He tells her, 'the pain will only last a second. It won't hurt too bad if you do it right.' She does exactly as he says. She believes him. And he was right, you know. The pain didn't last too long, and she followed him to this world he so fondly spoke of.

"They were both happy there. He was by her side, they remained friends. They went on adventures, saw mountains and valleys and cities with buildings that reached higher than the clouds."

His golden eyes meet her eyes again, a solemn look on his face. "I know a world without pain, Lilith," he whispers. "All you have to do is carve your way there."

"Carve my way..." she echoes quietly. "I can leave home. Cut ties with my parents. Take Misha with me."

Aries tilted his head slightly, processing the answer for a long moment. "Yeah... yeah, you can do that, Lilith." He rests his forehead against hers, his hand resting at the back of her neck. "I'm glad you see reason," he whispers. "I'm glad I've convinced you to run."